there considering it below their dignity to deal with a woman. It was only when they realized that Veena was not going to back down, did they grudgingly sign off on the forms. Then, of course, hiring a truck to load the container on, moving it to Cariappa Vihar, unloading and lugging all the cartons all the way to the third floor. It was a difficult job, that too in the hot and humid summer months, but in no time, our new home was ready. Isha was, of course, a great help as also her friend Simon, who was her colleague in the same dance company, Danceworx, where Isha was working, Amala still being away in Singapore.

By then, I had left to take up my new assignment. I reported at Guwahati, where an NCO from 'my' Brigade had come to receive me. Since it was already late evening, we stayed in a nearby guest room, it being unsafe to drive at night in an insurgency-prone area; the ULFA and other splinter groups still being active. The next morning, I wore my uniform with my Brigadier badges of rank and the gorget patches with one star on the collar of my shirt. No fanfare, no one even to witness this 'promotion', which I had waited two and a half years for. We then drove in convoy to Phulbari, with a protection vehicle to the front and rear. It was as if I had never been away. En route, we halted at the transit camp at Kharupetia, famous for its dosas and coffee.

Just as it had been done for the Division, the raising of the Brigade had also been well thought through. For each Division, the commensurate number of Battalions had also to be raised. On raising, these new Battalions were sent to old, well-established Brigades in peace stations, where the new Battalions could settle in. From these Brigades, the older Battalions, as part of the normal turnover, would be sent to the new raising Brigade in the field. For 106 Infantry Brigade, two Battalions had been allotted, namely 10 MADRAS and 7 BIHAR. The third Battalion was to come later.

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